

Stuffed Japanese eggplant

Believe it or not, eggplant is actually a fruit, specifically a berry. There are several interesting varieties besides the fat oblong, round, or pear-shaped types we are accustomed to. One of them, the Japanese eggplant, which I prefer in this recipe, is a **beautiful**, slender, light purple specimen with tender, slightly sweet flesh. It has a lovely creamy texture and attractive purple skin.

1 medium red potato, scrubbed and cut into small dice

½ pound tomatoes [250g]

2 Japanese eggplants

2 tablespoons pine nuts

1 small red onion, finely chopped

2 tablespoons olive oil

3 garlic cloves, minced

1 teaspoon dried oregano

1 teaspoon dried basil

1½ teaspoons red miso

1 to 2 tablespoons fresh lemon juice

Salt and freshly ground pepper

4 ounces Monterey Jack cheese, shredded [125g]

Shredded fresh basil, for garnish

1. Steam or boil the diced potatoes until tender, about 5 minutes. **Drain** and rinse under cold running water; drain well. Put the potatoes in a medium bowl.
2. Preheat the broiler with the rack set 5 to 6 inches [13 to 15cm] from the heat. Place the tomatoes on a baking sheet and **broil**, turning with tongs, until the skin is blistered and slightly charred all over, 3 to 5 minutes. Peel off the skins and coarsely chop the tomatoes. Add to the potatoes.
3. Preheat the oven temperature to 350°F [175°C]. **Slice** the eggplants in half lengthwise; brush lightly with oil and place cut side down on the baking sheet. Bake for 20 minutes, or until just tender. Remove from the baking sheet and let cool. Slice each piece lengthwise in half again so you have 8 long wedges.

4. With a spoon, gently **scoop** out the cooked eggplant, being careful not to tear the skin. Coarsely chop the eggplant and add to the potatoes and tomatoes. Set the skins aside separately.
5. **Toast** the pine nuts in a large dry skillet over medium heat, stirring often, until lightly browned, 2 to 3 minutes. Set aside in a small dish.
6. In same pan, **cook** the red onion in the olive oil over medium heat until very soft and lightly browned, 5 to 7 minutes. Add the garlic, oregano, and basil and stir for about 30 seconds, until fragrant.
7. Increase the heat to medium-high. **Add** the potatoes, tomatoes, chopped eggplant, miso, and 1 tablespoon of the lemon juice. Cook, stirring often, until the excess liquid evaporates and the mixture begins to thicken, 3 to 5 minutes. Remove from the heat and stir in the pine nuts. Season with salt and pepper to taste. Add more lemon juice, if desired.
8. Let the vegetable mixture cool a bit, then spoon into the eggplant skins. **Top** with shredded cheese and place on a lightly oiled baking sheet. Ideally, cover and refrigerate the dish at this point, giving everything a chance to set nicely. When ready to eat, place the eggplant boats under a preheated broiler until the stuffing is reheated and the cheese melts, about 2 minutes. Garnish with basil before serving.

SERVES 2 TO 4

